Human-Agent Interaction Patterns

1. Autonomy is a dial, not a switch

Five patterns describe every hand-off between people and agents, each with a different trust and control profile.

✎ DIAGRAM

Pattern	Who initiates → who acts	Example
Agent Calls Human	agent escalates to a person	loan agent pauses on an ambiguous case
Human Delegates to Agent	person hands over a goal	delegating market research
Human Calls Agent	person invokes for a task	checking an order status
Agent Delegates to Agent	agent hands a sub-task on	lead agent splits a financial analysis
Agent Calls Proxy Agent	agent talks to another org's proxy	cross-company loyalty programme

The five human-agent interaction patterns.

2. Agent Calls Human: the safety keystone

- When confidence is low or stakes are high, the agent **pauses and escalates** instead of acting
- You get most of the automation benefit while a human backstops the consequential decisions
- Design the **escalation triggers** deliberately: confidence thresholds, risk categories, ambiguity
- It's also part of the business case: production systems automate 60 to 80% and escalate the rest

3. Agent Calls Proxy Agent

- Makes cross-organisation collaboration possible: your agent never touches the other company's internals, only a proxy that represents them, preserving boundaries and trust

✎ DIAGRAM



Set the dial by the cost of an error and whether it can be reversed.

SAY IT

"Autonomy is a dial: the agent acts on routine cases and escalates to a human when confidence is low or the stakes are high, with the triggers designed deliberately."